



Laser focus: Few sports demand balance like 10m air rifle. Hitting a 0.5mm bullseye is brutal enough, let alone while pregnant.

Meghana says she didn't realise how big a deal it would become.

"When I realised I was pregnant last year, I didn't have any doubt that I would be training and competing as long as possible. My doctor also told me that there wouldn't be any issue until the last month of pregnancy, and that confidence encouraged me. I'd also read about how Serena Williams was playing tennis very late in her pregnancy, and I thought that if she could do it in a sport that's so physically demanding, I could do it in shooting,

which is far less strenuous," she says.

Her coach, Rakesh Manpat, with whom she trains in Bengaluru, was taken aback at first. "I only heard about someone competing so late in their pregnancy once before. It was at the 2002 Commonwealth Games. That athlete was coached by (former national coach) Laszlo Suchak, who had been my coach. So I thought, let me try to figure out how to give Meghana the help she needed," he says.

Multiple challenges

The challenges were obvious. Consistency is everything in a precision sport. Rifle shooters try to keep their body shape and weight as stable as possible. "I competed in

2001 when I was five months pregnant, but I was taking part in the prone event, where it's easier to adjust. The margins in 10m air rifle are so small that even a 100-gram increase in bodyweight or a centimetre gained or lost throws your shooting base and balance off," says national coach Deepali Deshpande.

That, of course, wasn't possible for Meghana. "I can't just think about fitness, but also about the fact that I have a child now. My diet has to change accordingly. In terms of training, I think the balance was a little difficult to get because my body was changing every day. Every day, I had to adjust my balance. There were some days when things were easier and other days when it was